ILLUSTRATIONS OF



CONFUCIAN TEMPLE, PEKING.

CHINA AND ITS PEOPLE.

VOL. II.

ILLUSTRATIONS OF CHINA

AND ITS PEOPLE.

A SERIES OF TWO HUNDRED PHOTOGRAPHS, WITH LETTERPRESS DESCRIPTIVE OF THE PLACES AND PEOPLE REPRESENTED.

BY J. THOMSON, F.R.G.S.

"Of Sericana, where Chineses drive
With sails and wind their cany waggons light."
MILTON, *Paradise Lost*, Book III.

IN FOUR VOLUMES.

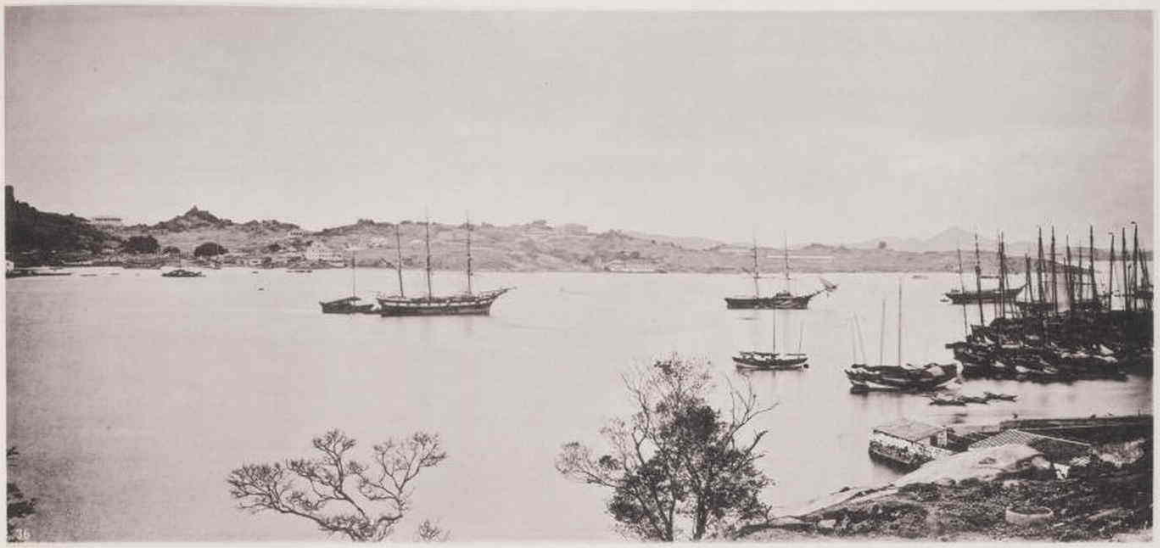
VOLUME II.

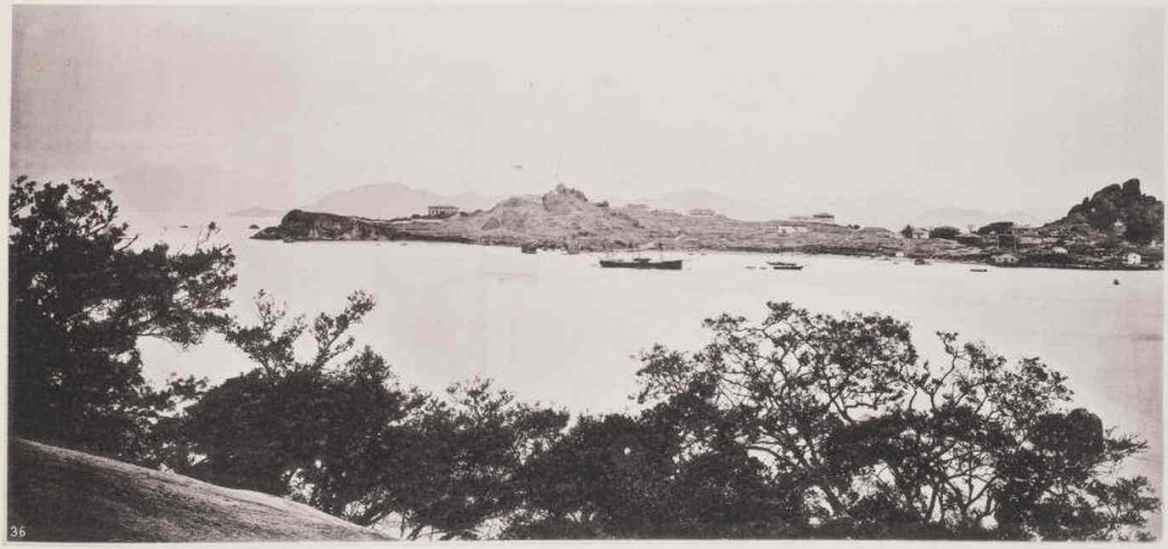
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SAMPSON LOW, MARSTON, LOW, AND SEARLE,
CROWN BUILDINGS, 188, FLEET STREET.
1873.

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KULANGSU.

THE island of Kulangsu, in the Fukien province, forms part of the western boundary of Amoy Harbour, and presents a picturesque appearance when viewed from the granite heights of Amoy Island opposite. It was from these heights that the two photographs No. 36 were taken, but they lack the warm colouring and the green slopes which intersperse them. We miss, too, the bright patches of cultivated garden ground, and the belt of yellow sand which runs like a golden setting round this island gem. The girdle of the deep blue sea lends additional beauty to this charming spot, which owes so much to the effect of colour. Scattered over this small island is a native population of more than 3000 souls. Many of these are fishermen, and as Kulangsu is the place where the bulk of the Amoy foreigners reside, a considerable proportion of the local inhabitants are engaged in supplying the wants of the Europeans. Before the capture of Amoy by our forces on August 27th, 1841, this island, along with the others which surround the harbour, were strongly fortified with batteries, so as entirely to command the mouth of the harbour. Many of these defences had been thrown up only a fortnight previous to the time when they opened fire on our ships. The forts themselves could not be silenced until our men had disembarked and driven out their gallant defenders. The latter fought bravely enough, and it is recorded by Dr. Williams, that their heroic leader, Kiang-kiyun deliberately drowned himself in the harbour to escape the disgrace of surviving his defeat.





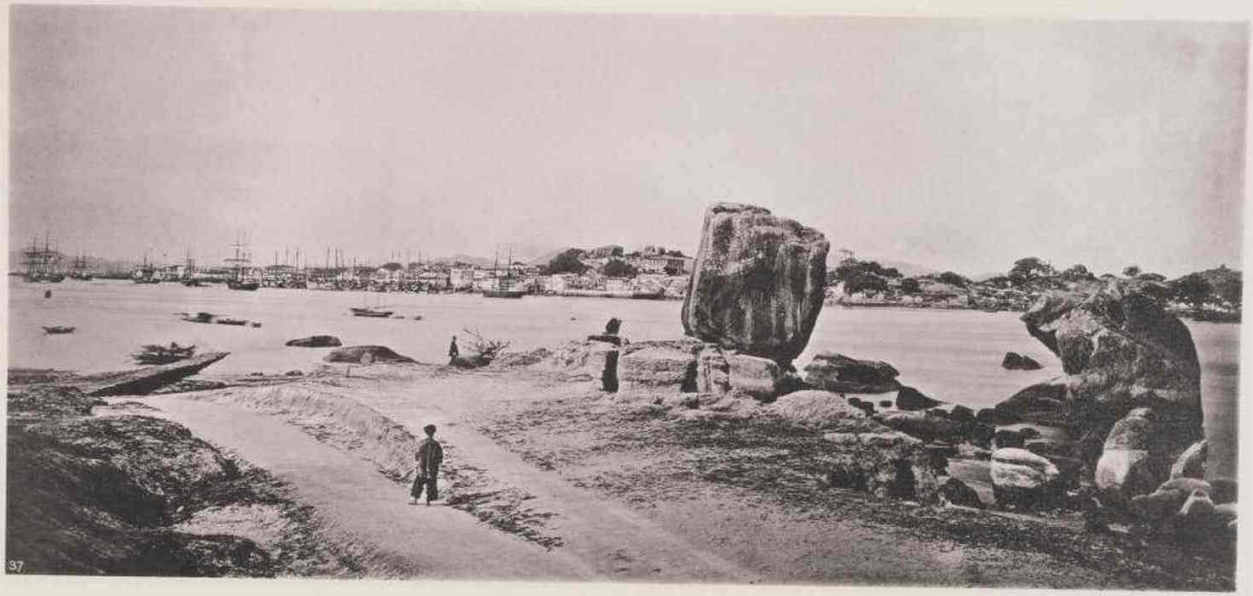
AMOY HARBOUR.

AMOY was one of the earliest ports to which foreigners resorted. About thirty-six miles north of this place is Chin-chew, known to Marco Polo by the name of Taitun, and, about the beginning of the ninth century, the centre of the local export trade. Amoy harbour is one of the finest on the Chinese coast, and at the points from which plate No. 37 was taken, is more than 800 yards across, thus it offers abundance of anchorage-ground for vessels even of the largest size. There is a maximum difference between high and low water mark here of about eighteen feet. The action of the tide has corroded the basis of many of the bold rocks inside the harbour basin, and a notable instance of this is to be seen in the upright mass of granite which stands in the foreground of this picture, and which is known by Europeans as "Six-mile Rock," and by the Chinese as the "Sail Windlass Rock."

To this pinnacle of stone, popular superstition is attached, for the natives look upon it as a kind of guardian genius who has control over the fates of Amoy. When this rock falls (say the credulous) Amoy will fall too. So year by year additional props are planted beneath its gradually diminishing base. In 1544 the Portuguese attempted to establish a settlement on this part of the coast, but the authorities there, more fortunate than they have been since in Macao, made the place too hot to hold the intruders. In 1624 a second attempt to tap the commercial resources of the district was commenced by the Dutch, who endeavoured to establish themselves on Fisher's Island. This position they afterwards exchanged for Formosa, and from the latter they were finally driven in Koksingá's time. Amoy was thrown open to foreign trade by the treaty of Nanking. The chief exports from this part of Fukien are sugar and tea, a great part of the latter article being grown in the north of Formosa. The import trade is now very much in the hands of the Chinese merchants, who avail themselves of the coast steamers to run to Hongkong to buy their wares, and who, if persons of respectability and standing, find every facility afforded to them by the banks in carrying on their commercial undertakings, however small their own capital may be. The irregular, illegal system of inland transit dues is very damaging to foreign trade, and effectually excludes European wares from many of the marts of the interior. Goods on being transported inland, although they have paid the legitimate port dues, are subject to a system of irregular taxation or squeezing, the amounts which are levied fluctuating with the need of the local officials at different points along the route.

During the war, a tax called le-kin was also imposed to meet the military expenditure. This tax is still levied on foreign merchandize at Amoy, while Swatow and the other ports on the coast, except Formosa, are none of them similarly burdened. Part of the carrying trade from this port to Formosa, Singapore and Batavia is still done in junks, for these, as I believe, are less heavily taxed than square-rigged ships.

The photograph shows that part of the native town of Amoy where the offices of foreign merchants have been built, the town itself stands on the west of the island from which it takes its name.



AMOY WOMEN.

MANY are the old women whom I have seen, and many are the nationalities to which they have belonged; but, in justice to them all, I feel bound to admit that I have not found one who does not possess the little "tache" of nature which makes them akin—a predilection, that is, for sitting and talking about their neighbours' affairs, and for gossiping over the tittle-tattle of the place where they reside. The two old women of my illustration proved no exception to the rule. I fell in with them as they stood in confabulation, and suggested that they would find it easier if they were to sit down to their work. At the time I arrived the elder of the two—she with the black patch on her temple—was recounting the hours of suffering caused her by an acute headache, and how the physician had effected a cure by applying a small round piece of black plaister. This, when removed, she would stick dutifully upon the doctor's door, as a proof of its efficacy in alleviating pain. Her companion is employed by foreigners to nurse their children; she is a woman of a kindly nature, who does her own duty well, but carefully abstains from putting her hand to extraneous work, or drudgery of any kind. To her mistress she is cheerful, civil, and obedient; but her vocabulary to the children under her charge is not always the most select; indeed, she has a ready knack of showing her displeasure, by a free use of vile epithets which their fond mother is fortunately unable to understand. The pay of a good nurse in China is about £24 a-year, out of which sum she has to find herself in food. See No. 38.

SMALL FEET OF CHINESE LADIES.

THIS picture, No. 39, shows us the compressed foot of a Chinese lady, and I regard it as one of the most interesting in my collection. Who the lady is, or where she came from, I cannot say. I had been assured by Chinamen that it would be impossible for me, by the offer of any sum of money, to get a Chinese woman to unbandage her foot, and yet gold and silver are arguments in favour of concessions which operate in the Celestial Empire with more than usual force. Accordingly, all my efforts failed until I reached Amoy, and there, with the aid of a liberal-minded Chinaman, I at last got this lady privately conveyed to me, in order that her foot might be photographed. She came escorted by an old woman, whom also I had to bribe handsomely before she would agree to countenance an act of such gross indecency as the unbandaging the foot of her charge. And yet, had I been able, I would rather have avoided the spectacle, for the compressed foot, which is figuratively supposed to represent a lily, has a very different appearance and odour from that most beautiful and sacred of flowers. Nothing would persuade the lady to raise her dress just high enough to show her ankles. The process of compressing the foot begins in early childhood; the bones of the instep being gradually bent down by continual bandages till they meet the heel in such a manner that the smaller toes almost disappear and become entirely useless. The cripple is thus reduced to supporting herself on the great toe and the ball of the heel. Dr. Dudgeon says, "The os calcis from being horizontal becomes vertical, and its posterior surface is brought to the ground. The bones of the instep are pushed out of their place and made to bulge, thus giving a great prominence, and an arched crescentic form, resembling the new moon, to that part." The points, then, upon which the foot rests, are the heel in its new position, the ball of the great toe, and the fourth and fifth toes, whose upper surfaces

have now become parts of the sole. Grave doubts exist about the origin of this artistic deformity of "golden lily feet;" some say it was a jealous husband, who, as already noticed, crippled his wife, that she might thus be more inclined to cultivate the pleasures of home. It is however related that his intentions were disappointed, for that the lady limped about upon her "golden lilies" and flirted abroad as before. The baneful practice is supposed to have come into fashion about the tenth century of our era. It is argued that it cannot have been of great antiquity, because Confucius and the early writers are silent on the subject. Tradition affirms that in 1122 B.C. an imperial lady had club feet, and that, in order to conceal her own defects from her lord, and keep him a stranger to the fair proportions of the feet of her maids, she ordered them to be bandaged. But, be the origin of the custom what it may, there can be no doubt, that it has been in vogue as a distinctive and peculiar institution among the Chinese for centuries past, and it is as much a mark of high breeding with their ladies, as vulture-claw nails are with their gentlemen. We despise so ridiculous a usage as this, but the following extract out of a native work will serve to show that the Chinese return us the compliment, and criticize us for deformities to which the inexorable requirements of fashion have given rise:[1] "The Yin-keih-le, or English females before marriage, bind their waist, being desirous to look slender."

The costume and general appearance of the men and women of Amoy are shown in Plates 40 and 41. The turbanned figure is an ordinary coolie, the type of the industrious labourer whose services are so highly rated in America and the other countries to which he emigrates. His habits of perseverance and economy gradually secure for him the reward of a modest competency, and if he resists the temptations of the opium pipe, and keeps aloof from the gaming tables, he will in a few years have amassed two or three hundred dollars, and with this he will embark as a farmer or a fisherman in his native land. Owing to the poverty of the people, in this part of Fukien, infanticide is still a common practice there, and it is of course the female children whom it is usual to sacrifice thus. In Amoy some of the wealthy Chinese do what they can to mitigate the evil by supporting a Foundling Hospital, where parents are paid a few cash, for bringing their children to be reared.

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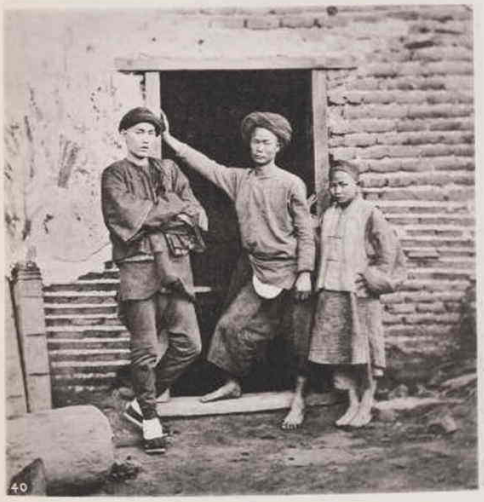
[1] "History of the Pirates," by F. Neumann; p. 29.



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